

Ashu Malik anointed a leader for future

Malik's understated approach, coupled with a **diverse skill set**, makes him a unique and effective player.

Saikat Chakraborty

saikat.chakraborty@thehindu.co.in

Ashu Malik, the young raider from Haryana, has represented Dabang Delhi KC for several seasons, quickly becoming one of the brightest stars in the Pro Kabaddi League (PKL).

A standout feature of Ashu's career has been his consistency as his team's crisis man. In the absence of the injured Naveen Kumar, Ashu has become the focal point of Delhi's attack over the past two seasons.

After finishing last season as the top scorer with the most raid points, the 22-year-old is again leading the PKL 11 charts with 139 points from 12 matches (as of November 20).

Calm under pressure, Ashu maintains a stoic demeanour on the mat. However, when he raids, he transforms into a formidable force.

Born into a farming family in Sonapat, Haryana — a region renowned for producing exceptional kabaddi players — Ashu was immersed in the sport from a young age. Watching his seniors play at Saraswati Vidya Mandir ignited his

passion and set him on the path to becoming an athlete.

"Kabaddi is very popular in my village. I first became captivated by the game watching my seniors play on our school's court. It wasn't long before I joined them," Ashu told *Sportstar*.

After climbing the local kabaddi ladder, from Under-14 to senior level, Ashu first caught the attention of PKL scouts through his performances in tournaments like the Yuva Kabaddi Series and K7 Kabaddi tournaments.

His standout performance in the 2022 Summer Yuva Kabaddi Series, where he scored 295 points in 26 matches, averaging 11.34 points per game, made waves in the kabaddi world.

"When that league started, I was unaware of its potential or impact. For me, it was just another tournament to play in. However, when I went there, I saw PKL coaches and realised this could be a pathway to Pro Kabaddi. Almost 90 per cent of the NYPs among all

teams have come through Yuva Kabaddi," recalls Ashu.

Dabang Delhi signed Ashu as a New Young Player (NYP) ahead of PKL 8. However, he had to adapt to the league's fast pace and live television pressure during his debut season.

"The team boasted a wealth of experienced players. Training alongside them, I understood the contrast between age-group kabaddi and the professional arena. From them, I learned tactical nuances, how to anticipate game situations, and even how to conduct myself on the mat," he recollects.

His PKL journey couldn't have started better — on his debut campaign in season 8, Delhi won its first-ever PKL title.

"I consider myself lucky to win the title in the first season. Many good players have played for 7-8 seasons without lifting the trophy," he adds.

The Roman philosopher Seneca's adage, "Luck is what happens when preparation meets opportunity," proved true for Ashu. After two